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PAST PERFECT

MANU PILLAI, 31

Author, London

Having graduated from Pune's Fergusson College, Manu Pillai's resume almost started to build itself. After a stint with Congress MP Shashi Tharoor, Pillai spent some time working at the House of Lords and then with the BBC World Service. More than these high-profile jobs themselves, what excited Pillai was the access they brought him. Working with Tharoor, he had the National Archives and the Kerala State Archives at hand. In the UK, he tuned to the British archives. Poring over those records paid off. Released when he was just 25, Pillai's first book, *The Ivory Throne: Chronicles of the House of Travancore*, was an instant hit. It even won him a Sahitya Akademi Yuva Puraskar in 2016. Pillai has since authored three more books. He doesn't just make women and the marginalised speak in his accounts of history, but his latest book *False Allies: India's Maharajahs in the Age of Ravi Varma* also forces us to revise our inherited notions of power. ■

–Shreevatsa Nevatia

> "I do hope 20 years down the line, I will have at least written enough books to fill one shelf"

PEOPLE PERSON When Pillai was in his teens, he used to inflict on his family his "atrocious" poetry and fiction. Slowly, as he heard more stories about his ancestors, he found he wanted to tell the history of people, not one of dates.

Honestly Speaking

AVNI DOSHI, 39

Author, Dubai

Shortlisted for the Booker Prize in 2020, *Burnt Sugar* (published in India as *Girl in White Cotton*) is, in many ways, Avni Doshi's labour of love. She started writing the novel in 2013 and the draft she finally submitted to her publisher was her eighth. Reading Doshi can be an unsettling and harrowing experience. Rather than pandering to her readers, she portrays human intention and action with an unflinching honesty. For her, the mother-daughter relationship, for instance, is hardly ever straightforward. It's with good reason that her novel's first line—"I would be lying if I said my mother's misery has never given me pleasure"—is quoted so often. While Doshi's book defied the toughest of odds—the pandemic—to succeed, it did also show that characters in a novel do not need that silver lining of redemption to be relatable. Doshi, it seemed, had infused into her fiction her own sense of delectable doubt. ■

–Shreevatsa Nevatia

> "I'm not an insider. Yet I've been able to find my own little place where I can write what I believe in"



SHARON HARIDAS

THE SAME BRUSH Before Doshi took to literature, she worked as an art writer and curator. Over time, she found the distinctions between the two disciplines blur significantly. In much the same way that art permeates her fiction–her *Burnt Sugar* protagonist is an artist–books fashioned her art career, too.